A subsequent debate ran with a number of members opposing the above resolution.

Arguments for Small Trains

A report on the best width for the proposed narrow gauge railways in India, and their applicability to the Indus Valley by John Fowler, addressed to the Under-Secretary of State for India, dated 25 October 1870, raised some pertinent points in support of the narrower railway gauges.

> I need scarcely remark that the introduction of a second gauge in a country which already possesses a great length of railway is a step of much responsibility. The evils of a break or difference of gauge are well known in England, America, Sweden and elsewhere; but notwithstanding this, there are many countries where the introduction of cheap railways on an exceptional gauge has become a necessity, to avoid the much greater evil of having no railway at all.
>
> On this question, as applied to the vast continent of India, I venture to point out here the danger of laying down a general principle. In some districts the population is so sparse, the goods for railway transit so few, and the probability of much increase so remote, that a cheap narrow-gauge system of railways may be introduced with financial and local advantage, and without any great risk of inconvenience from break of gauge; whilst in other districts, with a denser population, greater productive power, and considerable intercommunication, it would be as undesirable to introduce an exceptionable gauge as it would be in England, France or Germany. [78]

Fowler simply meant that it was not wise to apply a general rule for the track. Those who favoured smaller gauges largely did so from a social viewpoint, to build a faster railway with cheaper investment and economic prudence. However, those in favour of a uniform gauge across the country said it was imperative from a military point of view for quick movement of troops in case of mutinies and emergencies.

Nevertheless, small trains and lines flourished. At some places, they were the only links for communication and became crucial for the town's economy. At many other places, they were extensions of the main line.

Below are a few interesting narrations on smaller railways, their growth and their challenges.

BARODA RAILWAY: FROM BULLOCK POWER TO MOTIVE POWER